Dear parents, dear brother Armin, esteemed mourning guests, dear friends and comrades: Deeply moved we stand at the bier of our friend and comrade Egon Schultz. On 5 October he was insidiously murdered on GDR territory by bandits who came from West Berlin, now we must take leave of you, comrade NCO Egon Schultz. You were a genuine child of our republic, and you gave your best – your young prospering life – to the GDR, to your socialist homeland. Your life was short, but nevertheless very rich and happy.

Glorified as a martyr to socialism, dozens of collectives, schools and institutions were named after Egon Schultz.14

Meanwhile, over in Moscow, drama of a different sort was unfolding as Brezhnev finalised details of the Politburo meeting on 15 October which would oust Khrushchev into official oblivion. It was a day full of rumour and excitement. In his private notes when preparing the indictment, Brezhnev outlined the reasons. 'Why it all happened – because of a Khrushchev cult, developed with the direct and most active support of Khrushchev. I get the strong impression that clouded your awareness … the poison of unlimited power spoilt you.'

Just after 08.00, French wire agencies flashed that big news was about to break. Nobody guessed yet, including Ulbricht, that Khrushchev was on the way out. At four in the afternoon, Reuters flashed that an important announcement 'may be in preparation'. Finally, a dramatic bulletin on Radio Moscow, confirmed Khrushchev had retired 'in view of his age and the deterioration of his health'. By this point, the Politburo had offered the post of General Secretary to Brezhnev, who quickly established full command over Party structures.